

Japan Daily Brief

Sunday, September 20, 2026

1,398 words · 6 min read

RE: DPRK dual missile launch · BOJ rate check after 1.25% hike disappoints markets · Takaichi-Trump NY summit Tuesday · Global Hawk wreckage recovered · Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games open

NIKKEI 225
65,018.95
▲ +2.40%

USD/JPY
156.85
▲ +2.24%

BRENT
\$99.29
▼ -8.70%

BOJ RATE
1.25%

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 North Korea fired two suspected short-range ballistic missiles into the East Sea today — the second launch in two weeks — with both falling outside Japan's EEZ, per Japan and South Korean military confirmation.
- 2 The BOJ conducted a rate check lifting the yen toward the upper-156 range after the dollar pushed past 158 following the bank's split-decision 1.25% hike, which markets deemed insufficient.
- 3 The Japan Self-Defense Force recovered wreckage from the crashed US Global Hawk unmanned reconnaissance aircraft along the western Japan coast, confirming Kyodo's breaking news report.

• TOP STORIES

DPRK

North Korea fires two suspected ballistic missiles into East Sea; both fall outside Japan's EEZ

North Korea launched two suspected ballistic missiles toward the East Sea on September 20, with South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff confirming both launches and reporting one flew approximately 450 km from Wonsan. Japan's government confirmed neither fell within Japan's exclusive economic zone; Tokyo has tightened security in response.

per The Japan Times: "North Korea fires ballistic missile into waters outside Japan EEZ - The Japan Times"

THE JAPAN TIMES

ALLIANCE

Takaichi-Trump bilateral set for Tuesday in New York ahead of US-China summit

Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** has confirmed a summit with President **Donald Trump** on Tuesday in New York on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly, framed urgently against the backdrop of an anticipated Trump-Xi summit. The meeting is the first Takaichi-Trump bilateral and comes days after Japan's cabinet reshuffle.

per Nikkei Asia: "Takaichi seeks Trump meeting early next week ahead of US-China summit"

NIKKEI ASIA

DEFENSE

JASDF recovers wreckage of crashed US Global Hawk drone off western Japan coast

Japan's Air Self-Defense Force confirmed recovery of part of a crashed US Global Hawk unmanned reconnaissance aircraft along the western Japan coast. The incident drew high-level editorial attention at Nikkei Asia, which published an internal account of its coverage.

per Mainichi: "SDF recovers part of crashed Global Hawk drone along western Japan coast"

MAINICHI

• OVERNIGHT

ECONOMY-BOJ Yen vulnerable with Japan on holiday after BOJ disappoints markets · Bloomberg Japan

Bloomberg flags yen vulnerability on Japanese public holiday following the BOJ's 1.25% hike, which markets deemed insufficient. The currency had already slid past 158 before the subsequent rate check pulled it back toward the upper-156 range.

ECONOMY-BOJ Nippon Life plans \$13 billion for US data center financing · Reuters

Japan's Nippon Life Insurance is planning *\$13 billion* in financing for data centers in the United States, per Nikkei Asia reporting cited by Reuters. The commitment represents a major Japanese institutional capital flow into US digital infrastructure.

POLITICS-DIET Bomb threats sent to Okinawa governor-elect Koja's children's schools · Mainichi

Okinawa Governor-elect **Genta Koja** reported receiving bomb threats directed at his children's schools and the prefectural government building following his election win. The threats escalate political tensions surrounding the gubernatorial transition in Okinawa, which hosts the bulk of US forces in Japan.

ALLIANCE Ukraine requests Zelenskyy-Takaichi meeting on UN sidelines · Mainichi

The Ukrainian government formally requested a bilateral meeting between President **Volodymyr Zelenskyy** and Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly. The request adds to a dense Takaichi diplomatic schedule in New York that already includes a Trump summit on Tuesday.

• STAT OF THE DAY

58,000

Drones per year — Prodrone's planned annual mass-production capacity

Japan's Prodrone is gearing up to manufacture 58,000 drones annually, reflecting the scale of Japan's defense-industrial drone buildup.

Japan's Prodrone gears up to mass produce 58,000 drones a year — Nikkei Asia

• JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

PM Watch: PM appeared today · 0 day(s) since last confirmed appearance — PM Takaichi is en route to or present in New York for the UN General Assembly, with a confirmed Trump bilateral set for Tuesday and a Ukrainian bilateral meeting request pending, following her instruction to the new cabinet to focus on market stability and the Middle East.

外務省 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA draws public criticism over costumes used in anti-terror drill at Tokyo government facility

Japan's Foreign Ministry faced public backlash over the costumes worn by participants in an anti-terror drill held at a government facility in Tokyo designed to prepare for potential attacks and abduction of Japanese nationals abroad. The specific nature of the criticism is reported by the Japan Times and Manila Bulletin.

→ The Japan Times ↗

官邸 · KANTEI (PRIME MINISTER'S OFFICE) · Sanae Takaichi, Prime Minister

PM Takaichi instructs new cabinet to prioritize market stability and Middle East response

Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** directed her reshuffled cabinet to focus on market conditions and Japan's response to the Middle East situation. The directive follows the September 17 reshuffle and comes ahead of her New York visit for the UN General Assembly and Tuesday summit with President Trump.

→ Nikkei Asia ↗

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT & APPROVAL POLLING

POLLSTER	APPROVE	DISAPPROVE
Yomiuri · Sep 19, 2026	59%	30%
FNN · Sep 15, 2026	61.6%	32.2%
NHK · Sep 10, 2026	52.8%	30.8%
JNN · Sep 7, 2026	62.5%	34.9%
Nikkei · Sep 5, 2026	62%	32%
Asahi · Sep 5, 2026	53%	33%
ANN · Sep 5, 2026	55.4%	29.9%
Kyodo · Sep 10, 2026	50.2%	33.9%

Discourse: Post-reshuffle approval recovery across Kyodo (53%), Yomiuri (59%), and Nikkei (62%) polls contrasts with a pre-reshuffle Jiji low of 44.1% and a Mainichi reading of 41%; fiscal credibility remains the principal drag, with 71% of Kyodo respondents worried about fiscal health after Japan's food tax cut.

REGIONAL PRESSURE WATCH

High — 79 items (61 DPRK, 14 BOJ, 3 Chief Cabinet Sec, 1 MOFA)

CHINA

No new China Coast Guard, PLA, or MOFA incidents toward Japan are reported today; Global Times continues its framing of Japan's military revival as a regional threat, and Chinese state media published a piece debunking what it calls 'colonial glorification' of Japanese rule in Taiwan, sustaining the historical-narrative pressure campaign. Chinese tourist arrivals to Japan fell *59%* year-on-year in August, per Global Times, a data point intersecting with China's visa-fee retaliation measures in effect since mid-September.

NORTH KOREA

North Korea fired two suspected short-range ballistic missiles on September 20 — the second launch in two weeks — into the East Sea; South Korea's JCS reports one flew approximately 450 km from the Wonsan area. Both fell outside Japan's EEZ. Japan tightened security in response. Separately, reporting surfaces that North Korea has fired approximately 150 ballistic missiles at Ukraine, with the same missile types posing threats to Japan.

Senkaku / ECS: No new CCG patrol or intrusion data reported in today's articles; baseline pattern of near-daily contiguous zone presence continues from prior reporting.

Bottom line: North Korea's second ballistic missile launch in two weeks — both falling outside Japan's EEZ — is the day's primary adversary signal; the launches follow two weeks after the September 12 joint firepower drill and come as Takaichi heads to New York for a Tuesday Trump summit where DPRK deterrence posture will be on the agenda.

• U.S.-JAPAN RELATIONS

ALLIANCE · ARAB NEWS

Japan to send independent force to Middle East; declines to join US coalition

Japan confirmed it will dispatch its own military contingent to the Middle East independently rather than joining a US-led coalition, a distinction that reflects constitutional and political constraints on collective action even as Japan-US security coordination deepens.

• INDO-PACIFIC PARTNERS

PACIFIC ISLANDS · STRAITS TIMES

Japan grants up to \$3.5 million for Solomon Islands elections

Japan announced grant assistance of up to \$3.5 million for the Solomon Islands elections, extending Tokyo's Pacific Islands engagement in a geopolitically contested sub-region.

INDIA · NIKKEI ASIA

Sojitz chip materials hub for Tata India fab deepens Japan-India semiconductor ties

Sojitz's logistics hub for the Tata semiconductor fab in India expands Japan's supply-chain footprint in a key Quad partner and diversifies Japanese chip-materials networks away from China-dependent routes.

• THE WIRE

ALLIANCE • REUTERS JAPAN

Reuters: Takaichi working to arrange Trump meeting, NHK reports

Reuters reported, citing NHK, that PM Takaichi was actively working to arrange a bilateral with Trump on the UN sidelines, with the meeting since confirmed for Tuesday, September 22.

• UPCOMING

Sep
22

Takaichi-Trump bilateral summit, New York (UN sidelines)

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is scheduled to meet President Donald Trump on Tuesday on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly. The meeting is framed as urgent ahead of a planned Trump-Xi summit, with tariffs and alliance posture on the agenda.

Sep
22

PM Takaichi addresses UN General Assembly

Takaichi is scheduled to deliver Japan's statement at the UN General Assembly on September 22, her first as Prime Minister.

Sep
22

Zelenskyy-Takaichi bilateral requested by Ukraine (UN sidelines)

The Ukrainian government has formally requested a meeting between President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and PM Takaichi on the UN sidelines, per Kyodo. Timing and confirmation remain pending.

Oct
5

Extraordinary Diet session convenes

Japan's government has confirmed the extraordinary Diet session will open on October 5, covering fiscal policy and the post-reshuffle legislative agenda.

Oct
21

First anniversary of Takaichi Cabinet inauguration

The Takaichi Cabinet marks one year in office, a natural benchmark for approval rating assessments and potential policy reviews; approval currently stands at 53% (Kyodo, post-reshuffle) after recovering from a record low.

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